

Guoquan (2517.HK, NC): APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day 2026

Takeaways: Jun on a tough base; large-store revamps driving SSSg

APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day
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We met with Guoquan (Not Covered) in-person in Hong Kong on Jul 3 during our APAC Consumer Corp Day. **Key Takeaways include:**

1) 2Q26 performance in-line, full-year guidance maintained: Mgmt shared top-line growth moderation in 2Q26, April/May 26 was up MSD%/LSD% YoY on flat ticket sizes, while June faced a high base (2024/25 Jun SSSg at 30%+/MSD%), coupled with a soft macro backdrop. 1H26 GPM was manageable despite impacts from lower-margin livestreaming and raw materials, mitigated by locked in prices and volumes in advance, adjusted product mix, and domestic beef supply. That said, mgmt expects 2026 profit growth to outpace revenue.

2) 1H26 store openings on track with shift to large formats into 2H: The company is on track for its store openings in 1H26. Since 2Q26, the strategy has shifted toward larger-format stores, making minimum size requirements mandatory in 2H26. Consequently, 2H26 evaluations will prioritize revenue contribution over store count, supported by elevated 1H26 operational and marketing investments.

3) Large-Store upgrades deliver 30%+ SSSg and strong payback: The core large-store revamp strategy is progressing well, with 500+ stores upgraded by end-May (targeting 2,000-3,000 over 2-3 years), yielding 30%+ SSSg in Jan-May 2026. Despite higher upfront costs of Rmb200K (vs. Rmb140K for standard stores), large formats offer superior productivity with a 1.5-year payback period and positive store-level EBITDA.

4) New formats & product expansion: The camping format is scaling rapidly with 100+ sites active or preparing by end-May, while the stir-fry format remains in pilot. Product expansion like frozen durian (launched March) use online-to-offline pickup to extend store reach, while carrying lower GPMs, these initiatives build supply chain capabilities and drive traffic.

5) Shareholder returns: Mgmt committed to semiannual dividends with a payout of no less than 60% of the buyback amount. Up to 100 million repurchased shares will be reserved for equity incentives, with the remainder canceled before the next AGM. Off-balance-sheet cold-chain assets will not be injected to avoid compliance and tax

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costs.

More details within.

1. 2Q26 Updates & 2026 Guidance:

- **Revenue:** Mgmt shared top-line growth moderation in 2Q26, April/May 26 was up MSD%/LSD% YoY on flat ticket sizes, while June faced a high base (2024/25 Jun SSSg at 30%+/MSD%), coupled with a soft macro backdrop.
- **Store openings:** Mgmt shared 1H26 store openings were broadly on track, with strategic shift towards larger-format stores since 2Q26, minimum size requirements are rising and will become mandatory in 2H26. 3Q26-4Q26 openings will focus mainly on large stores, with evaluation shifting from store count to revenue contribution given the higher productivity of large stores.
- **Expenses:** 1H26 spending was elevated and focused primarily on the large-store strategy. Investments included dedicated offline staff to support franchisees in optimizing operations, merchandising, and in-store execution for larger formats, as well as higher marketing spending and store-opening subsidies.
- **Raw Material:** Management said raw material cost volatility remains manageable, aided by close upstream tracking. Main pressure comes from geopolitical risks and oil price fluctuations, particularly rising beef prices given the company's still high imported beef exposure. In response, the company has locked in prices and volumes in advance, adjusted product mix, and built domestic beef supply as a substitute. For crayfish, management said it has been closely tracking raw material trends and plans to deepen upstream involvement once the factory begins operations.
- **Margins:** Mgmt maintained its 2026 target for profit growth to outpace revenue growth, while acknowledging 1H GPM pressure from lower-margin livestreaming products used to support supply chain development and store traffic, as well as raw material cost pressure.

2. Product Expansion: Frozen durian, launched in March, is an important test case for the company's agricultural product strategy, using online sales plus in-store pickup to extend store reach beyond physical space constraints. While the category has faced temporary supply disruptions due to sourcing and inventory preparation, management views its value not only in sales contribution but also in building supply chain capabilities and driving store traffic, albeit at lower GPM vs. core products. The company is also developing adjacent durian products and testing additional categories such as eggs, frozen seafood, and potentially bakery products for large-format stores.

3. Large Store Revamp Updates & UE: Large-store upgrades are a core 2026 strategy, with 500+ completed by end of May and further progress in June (vs. 2-3 years target of revamping 2,000-3,000 stores). Management said upgraded stores delivered 30%+ SSSg in Jan-May 2026, with some early pilot stores reaching c.50% revenue growth in Feb before moderating. Compared with standard stores, large stores require higher upfront investment (Rmb200K, with 14+ fridges and store size of 80 sqm+ vs. Rmb140K, with 6 fridges and store size of 50-100 sqm for normal stores) but offers meaningfully stronger sales productivity, with payback still within about 1.5 years. Management also noted that actual franchisee investment has been lower than the static unit economics model

implies due to company subsidies and external cost-sharing. Offline stores are now positive at both the EBITDA and store-level profit level.

4. New store formats: The company is developing two new store formats, camping and stir-fry, with camping scaling faster. After a successful pilot in Zhengzhou in September 2025, the camping format began replicating in 2026, with 100+ sites either opened or under preparation by end-May. Management sees a first-mover advantage in camping given its differentiated supply chain capabilities, although expansion remains labor-intensive due to fragmented site selection and limited standardization. On the other hand, the stir-fry format is still in the pilot refinement stage, with broader roll out likely in 2027 after the model is validated.

5. Comments on franchise model: Management said the main appeal of large-store upgrades for franchisees is higher absolute sales and profit rather than better margins or faster payback. Rollout depends largely on store conditions and franchisees' willingness to invest more, with upgrades easier at larger existing sites or where adjacent space can be added, while relocations move more slowly. The company also sees this as a way to upgrade franchisee quality, as large-store operators differ from those willing to invest only in smaller formats.

6. M&A & Shareholder returns: Management shared it is not currently considering injecting off-balance-sheet cold-chain assets into the listed company, as doing so would raise compliance, tax, fleet management, and warehouse upgrade costs. That said, the company may continue to explore suitable capital arrangements internally. On shareholder returns, up to 100 mn repurchased shares will be reserved for equity incentives, with the remainder to be canceled before next year's AGM, while the company will continue semiannual dividends with payout set at no less than 60% of the buyback amount.

7. Overseas expansion: Management said overseas expansion will be a gradual, long-term effort, with no expectation of near-term rapid progress. However, the Hong Kong store is expected to open by end-July, marking an initial step forward.

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